

F

FOR ASSAM-BASED Bhavjot Kaur, 34, the motivation to innovate on the healthcare experience in India came from personal suffering. Her father was diagnosed with diabetes in 2006 and even after months of hospitalisation, they could not save him; he passed away in 2010. Not only did the ordeal strain her family emotionally, but also drained their finances. “We did not have any health insurance to take care of the financial impact. So, the family was emotionally and financially torn,” she says. The incident was a moment of realisation for Kaur, an IIT Roorkee student then. It showed her how broken healthcare was in India. Eight years later, along with her husband, orthopaedic surgeon Suraj Baliga, she set up Clinikk. “For me, it was important that I work on something that changed how healthcare is experienced in this country. That’s the motivation behind our company,” says Kaur.

Clinikk operates 16 primary care centres across Bengaluru, and two in Hyderabad, known as Clinikk Health Hubs. It offers virtual consultation, unlimited access to doctors, medicines, diagnostics and specialist consultation, all in exchange for a subscription fee. Till now, it has partnered with Hero MotoCorp and Vodafone, tech platforms like Ola, Rapido and Shadowfax and the Government of Goa to serve over 2 million customers.

All these services are available

in just one plan—something unheard of in a health plan, but these new-age health insurance start-ups—that call themselves managed-care service providers—have got you covered. And, while some don’t have a direct licence from the regulators yet, these firms are gaining traction as they transform the space with innovations like subscription-based and bite-sized plans. For instance, Onsurity offers plans exclusively for SMEs. The idea was born when Founders Yogesh Agarwal and Kulin Shah realised that there were no SME-focussed insurers in the country. “SMEs are underserved. When we talk about product offering and product servicing by the traditional insurers, they generally cater to retail customers. That’s how we started building Onsurity,” says Agarwal, who is also the CEO.

AN EMERGING SECTOR

According to a recent report by consultancy firm RedSeer, India’s insurance market is poised to grow

to \$222 billion by FY26 from \$117 billion in FY21, driven by a growing middle class, increasing digital penetration and new online distribution models.

As these start-ups innovate, experts divide them into three categories: One, those offering employee insurance and wellness plans, such as Plum and Nova Benefits. Second, retail-focussed companies that offer OPD subscription-based plans, like Clinikk and Kenko Health. Third are embedded insurance providers such as Zopper that democratise access to insurance.

Riding on this innovation wave is Bengaluru-based Kenko Health that offers instant benefit on all medical bills, including out-of-pocket expenses for medicines, lab tests, doctor consultations, emergency services, at-home care, mental health and the like. “Our subscribers don’t rely on tedious paperwork, third-party agents or different apps to access healthcare services. They get all these benefits on a single app. From an operational perspective,

| 95

COVER YOUR BASES

1

The monthly subscription-based model of managed-care service providers is gaining traction among people

2

These new-age start-ups cover doctor consultations and offer discounts on pharmacy and lab tests

3

They also provide health insurance to cover the cost of hospitalisation

4

Some of these start-ups, however, do not have a licence from regulator IRDAI

5

The regulator has issued notice to exercise caution while dealing with unregulated entities